

Renovators and Newcomers In Art Shows of the Week

By CARLYLE BURROWS

It is to his credit that an artist aims to avoid being taken for granted. By means of renovating, that is, his settled style of painting. Two very well known artists, Maurice Sievan, at Barone's, and Irving Marents at the Babcock Gallery, this week are exhibiting the different viewpoints they have adopted for their work. These are more or less in line with the expressionist process of today, though both manage, as a matter of course, to remain conscious of the world about them.

Figurative in a broad view are the giant-sized phantom images which Sievan substitutes for the realities of the past. Here are echoes of a distant world in which man moves but retains a stationary pose. It is in a gray mist that the figures exist, and move us to contemplation of a faint but still provocative fantasy. Sievan, who has shown himself expert at nuance in painting, contrives to be relaxed, mystical and sufficiently aware of the tides of today's painting all at one and the same time. His new work travels a fresh path.

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Maurice Sievan: One's first impression of the big, dim paintings of this show is that they are abstractions. The canvas is usually divided into two or three large areas by amorphous shapes painted in a palette of blacks, umbers and grays. But the proportions of these masses slowly assert themselves, and one sees that they are human figures. Now certain definite, though restrained references are unmistakable, like the droop of a head, with its evocation of pensive quiet. The figures are placed against smoky grays, which suggest distance or darkness, and consequently there is a looming quality to the central mass. *Epsephon* and *Aristad* are most explicit in their reference to the human. In these two paintings the bodies are less evaporated into the cloudy atmosphere; but still, the interior articulation of the silhouette is so indefinite that one's own imagination fills out the implications of gesture and posture. The brushwork is level, with occasional rubbing and very light spatter. (Barone, Apr. 26-May 21.)—G.D.

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Art: Balance and Tension

Maurice Sievan's new paintings at the Barone Gallery, 1018 Madison Avenue, are dominated by Gog- and-Magog-like figures looming in deep shadows. Mr. Sievan paints thinly and loosely, so that the figures dematerialize in their empty environment. The horrifying imagination of Goya is recalled here, as well as something peculiar to the modern and primitive painter: his premonition of catastrophe.

DORE ASHTON.